

SELF-LOADING RIFLES

Self-loading, or semiautomatic, rifles existed before the end of the 19th century. The first one was developed by Manuel Mondragon of Mexico in 1891, but like other early designs it proved too complex for military use. While some early self-loading rifles were recoil-operated (see p.305), others began utilizing a system of gas-driven reloading (see p.305). In 1917, French gunmakers introduced the St. Etienne self-loading rifle, while in the US, John M. Browning perfected his “automatic” rifle, the BAR (Browning Automatic Rifle). Both were in service in World War I. A later successful design was the M1 Garand rifle, designed by John Garand, which, with its numerous variations, saw widespread service in World War II. The German Sturmgewehr 44 had fully automatic firing capability, and led the way toward today’s assault rifles (see pp.250–51).

▼ M1 GARAND RIFLE

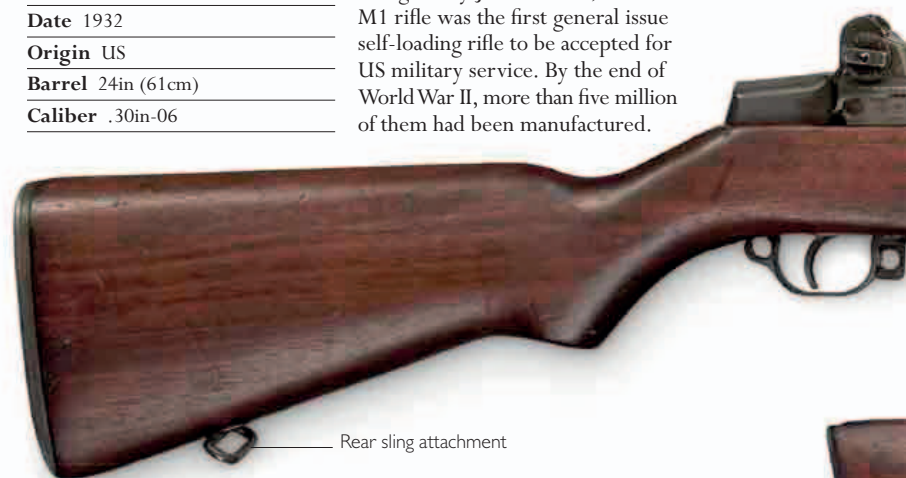
Date 1932

Origin US

Barrel 24in (61cm)

Caliber .30in-06

Designed by John Garand, the M1 rifle was the first general issue self-loading rifle to be accepted for US military service. By the end of World War II, more than five million of them had been manufactured.



Rear sling attachment



Threaded receiver cap

Integral magazine

▲ MONDRAGON RIFLE MODEL 1908

Date 1908

Origin Mexico/Switzerland

Barrel 24in (61cm)

Caliber 7mm

The Model 1908 Mondragon was the final version of a gas-operated, semiautomatic rifle first designed by Mexican General Manuel Mondragon in 1891. Though designed for infantry use, some rifles were issued to German air crew at the beginning of World War I.



Wooden butt

Rear sight

Cocking handle

15-round
detachable
box magazine

Rear sight

Welded
pressed-steel
receiver



Wooden butt

Pistol
grip

30-round
detachable
box magazine